Acknowledgements

In embarking on this captivating odyssey through the life and legacy of Babur, known as the ‘chessboard king’, I find myself humbly indebted to a constellation of individuals whose unwavering support, encouragement and influence have intricately woven the tapestry of this ambitious endeavour.

To the revered Bhagwan Ram, I attribute the true orchestration of this work, to feeling like a mere vessel through which this historical saga flows.

My heartfelt gratitude commences with Tejal Pardhy, my cherished life partner, whose steadfast encouragement and firm presence during life’s ebbs and flows have been a steady source of inspiration. Her unyielding support has ignited the flames of my passion for writing, urging me to persistently pursue this literary voyage.

To my esteemed parents, Atish Maldahiyar and Ruby Sinha, I owe an immeasurable debt of gratitude for their enduring blessings and unwavering support, serving as the guiding beacon illuminating my aspirations. Their unflagging belief in my endeavours has fortified my journey at every step.

My sincere appreciation extends to my in-laws, Kalidas Pardhy and Pradnya Pardhy, whose unwavering faith and blessings have consistently fortified my resolve to embark on this ambitious undertaking.

Reflecting on my formative years, the enchanting storytelling sessions with my grandmother, Shanta Devi, planted the seeds of narrative artistry within me. Although brief, my time with my late grandfather, Nath Sahay, continues to inspire me profoundly.

The untiring interest and blessings of my grandmother-in-law, Meenakshi Pardhy, and the unwavering advocacy of my sister Apoorwa and her husband Aman, serve as constant reminders of the expectations vested in me, compelling me to perpetually strive for excellence.

During my schooling at D.A.V. Public School, Hazaribagh, mentors and educators like Kiran Mishra, Sampa Srivastava, Pushpa Tiwari and the late Manoj Verma played pivotal roles in nurturing my passion for writing. Heartfelt gratitude to the ever-encouraging principal, Ashok Srivastava, for fostering an environment conducive to nurturing young talents.